

Cambridge IELTS 21

Academic Reading Test 3



3 Reading
Passages



40 Questions



60 Minutes

Candidate name:

Test date:

Test Instructions

General Rules

- The test contains three reading passages and 40 questions.
- Allow approximately 20 minutes for each passage.
- Read every instruction carefully before answering.
- Write answers in the spaces provided.
- Check spelling and word limits for completion tasks.
- Transfer and review all answers before the time ends.

Time Plan

01

Passage 1

Questions 1–13 — 20 minutes

02

Passage 2

Questions 14–26 — 20 minutes

03

Passage 3

Questions 27–40 — 20 minutes



Do not turn over until you are told to begin. Manage your time carefully — 20 minutes per passage is recommended.



You should spend about 20 minutes on Questions 1–13, which are based on Reading Passage 1 below.

Saving the saiga

The saiga, a species of antelope native to Central Asia, once roamed the vast grasslands of this region in enormous herds, many millions strong. Regrettably, such spectacular sights are a thing of the past. Today, the saiga is largely confined to a single country: Kazakhstan. This country is estimated to be home to well over 90% of the global saiga population, with Russia, Mongolia and Uzbekistan accounting for the rest.

The saiga is perfectly adapted to the tough conditions of the remote wilderness of the steppes of Central Asia. One such adaptation is its bizarre bulbous nose, which enables the animal to survive the extreme seasonal temperature swings of the region. The swollen nostrils of the nose serve several purposes: they filter out dust and cool the blood during hot, dry summers, and they warm the cold air before it enters the saiga's lungs in winter. Other seasonal adaptations include a heavy winter coat that the saiga sheds when the weather warms up.

Despite these superb adaptations to harsh conditions, the saiga has no defence against the threats posed by humans. It was almost driven to extinction by hunters in the 19th century. Legal protection ensured its survival for a while, and numbers steadily recovered throughout most of the 20th century. But the respite was only temporary. In the ten years following the break-up of the former Soviet Union in 1991, over 95% of the global population was lost - one of the fastest examples of species loss ever recorded for a mammal.

The dramatic decline during this decade was due to illegal poaching on an industrial scale. Male saiga are a particular target, because their horns are highly prized by traditional medicine practitioners. Poaching reached epidemic levels after misguided conservationists tried to relieve the pressure on threatened African rhinos by actively encouraging the use of saiga horns in traditional medicine as an alternative to those of rhinos. Male saiga were almost wiped out, leading to a population crash from which the species has been struggling to recover ever since.

Another threat to the survival of the saiga is loss of habitat, as a result of agricultural expansion and human settlement. Physical barriers such as railways, pipelines and fences can block the seasonal migration routes of this transboundary species. In the worst cases, herds may starve to death after being trapped.

Then there is the risk of disease. In 2015, an outbreak of haemorrhagic septicaemia, caused by the normally harmless bacterium *Pasteurella multocida*, killed over 75% of the global adult saiga population in just three weeks. In 2017, 60% of the Mongolian saiga population - a subspecies found nowhere else in the world - was killed by a virus that spilled over from livestock. These so-called mass mortality events represent an unpredictable and serious threat to the species.

Climate change poses a further threat. Although well adapted to cold winters and hot summers, saiga struggle to cope with temperature extremes and unpredictable fluctuations in climate. Experts believe that unusually warm weather may have triggered the 2015 mass mortality event. The steppe region has also become increasingly arid in recent years, and many of the smaller streams that the species normally depended on have dried up and vanished.

Recent efforts to save the saiga have been spearheaded by the Altyn Dala Conservation Initiative, a project led by the Association for the Conservation of Biodiversity of Kazakhstan, working in partnership with the Kazakh government's Committee for Forestry and Wildlife, Frankfurt Zoological Society and Fauna and Flora, an international conservation charity. Its purpose is to protect and restore Kazakhstan's steppe, semi-desert and desert ecosystems and the many species they support, including the critically endangered saiga. In 2022 the United Nations recognised the initiative as a World Restoration Flagship project, an accolade reserved for the ten best examples of large-scale ecosystem restoration around the globe.

So, how many saiga are there now? By 2000, the global saiga population had hit an all-time low of just 21,000 individuals. There was some recovery in the first decade of the new millennium but this was then crushed by devastating mass mortality events that saw the loss of hundreds of thousands of the species. But thanks to the intervention of the Altyn Dala Conservation Initiative, the most recent episodes in the ongoing story of the saiga have been relatively uplifting. Three years ago, the Ustyurt Plateau population in Kazakhstan experienced its largest mass birth of saiga calves in many years. An aerial census two years ago recorded an estimated 842,000 saiga across Kazakhstan as a whole, and according to an aerial survey earlier this year, the saiga population in Kazakhstan now exceeds 1.9 million. The world's strangest-looking antelope remains critically endangered, but the direction of travel is positive.

PART 1 — QUESTIONS

Part 1

Questions 1-7

Complete the notes below.

Choose ONE WORD ONLY from the passage for each answer.

The saiga

Adaptations

- has a large bulbous nose with swollen nostrils that
 - keep **1** 1 out
 - lower the temperature of its **2** 2 in summer
 - warm the air entering its lungs in winter
- grows a thick **3** 3 in winter, which it loses in spring

Reasons for population decline

- poaching, especially for the **4** 4 of male saiga
- expansion of farms and settlements, causing
 - reduction in the size of the saiga's **5** 5.
 - loss of access to the **6** 6 which they use for migration
- various forms of disease, leading to mass mortality events
- climate change, causing the disappearance of **7** 7 which the saiga relied on

Questions 8-13

Do the following statements agree with the information given in Reading Passage 1?

TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

8 Today, numbers of saiga are distributed evenly across four nations in Central Asia: Kazakhstan, Russia, Mongolia and Uzbekistan.

9 For most of the 20th century, the population of saiga were falling.

10 Efforts to protect rhinos in Africa had a significant effect on saiga populations.

11 Unpredictable fluctuations in climate are threatening the wildlife of Central Asia more than in other parts of the world.

12 The Altyn Dala Conservation Initiative was formed for the benefit of a number of different animals.

13 The Altyn Dala Conservation Initiative's recognition as a World Restoration Flagship project attracted additional international funding for the scheme.



You should spend about 20 minutes on Questions 14–26, which are based on Reading Passage 2 below.

The problems of getting around the city of Dar es Salaam

Dar es Salaam in Tanzania is one of the fastest growing cities in Africa. Its population has increased eightfold since 1980 and swells by half a million people every year. United Nations projections anticipate it will become a megacity within seven years as its population passes 10 million, reaching 13.4 million by 2035. Daniel Hoornweg for the Global Cities Institute forecasts the city could be home to an incredible 73.7 million people by 2100.

Today, four out of five of its people live in single-storey informal settlements on the spreading edges of the city, where the journey to and from the centre regularly takes over two hours. It can be longer if rain turns the dirt roads to mud.

Even in the middle of the day, traffic frequently slows to a stop without warning. It is not unusual for cars and minibuses to queue for 20 minutes at a key intersection. A single suburban rail line serves residents in a few areas to the south but is tiny in the context of the wider city. Outside the centre many rely on boda boda (motorbike taxis) to navigate the narrow side streets and potholed mud roads that make up much of the metropolis. Their safety record is scandalous.

Dar es Salaam's reliance on four arterial roads into the city is a legacy of the colonial government that planned the city at the start of the 20th century to cater for a population of 35,000. Most of the current growth is made up of young people arriving from the countryside to find work, and as the population has exploded, Dar es Salaam has grown around those four highways. Nearly all the expansion is happening on the periphery, and nearly all takes place informally without any agreed strategy.

But Dar es Salaam is pinning its hopes on a solution that could offer a different model for Africa's megacities, giving them an alternative to a future controlled by the private car. Unlike many cities on the continent, Dar es Salaam isn't trying to build a metro. It has chosen a less exciting but cheaper and more achievable method: the bus.

The DART bus rapid transit (BRT) system runs on bus lanes separated from other traffic, mostly in the middle of the road to reduce stoppages. Ticket purchase and control takes place at stations prior to boarding and the buses are step-free, which means the entire route is accessible to people using wheelchairs or who are travelling with baby buggies.

'The new buses are much, much better,' says Paulas George, a young IT worker. He takes the bus every day and it has cut his journey time by two-thirds. He says it is not perfect, though, complaining that drivers often refuse to turn on the air conditioning to save fuel.

That is not the only problem. A shortage of buses after a serious flood at the main depot during the rainy season means the system is carrying 200,000 people a day - half the expected capacity. Smartcards can't be used as the mechanical readers aren't working either, forcing passengers to buy individual paper tickets for every journey. Each is printed with a scannable QR code, but there are no scanners. Staff stand by the gates and tear tickets as people enter. As a result, queues are considerable at peak times.

Morogoro Road to the north-west of the city was phase I of the BRT project. Phases II and III will install bus lanes along Nyerere Road to the south-west and Kilwa Road to the south. Construction on both routes is due to start imminently. Phase IV, towards Bagamoyo in the north, is in the preliminary design stage. 'Much of the city will have access to a world-class transport system within the space of a few years,' says Chris Kost, the Africa director of ITDP (the Institute

for Transportation and Development Policy). All phases are being planned to high standards and, once complete, a third of city residents will be within a short walk of the BRT network.

The ITDP regrets Africa's obsession with metros. 'With a metro, an international firm will often just parachute in its own system,' says Kost. 'Bus rapid transit allows existing stakeholders to get involved. That's what we did in Dar es Salaam and what we're planning in Nairobi, where the bus bodies will be built in the city and local operators will look after tickets, fare collection and IT ...Bus rapid transit has been transformational for Dar es Salaam. For millions of people in African cities, this is their best hope of ever being connected.'

PART 2 — QUESTIONS

Part 2

Questions 14-18

Do the following statements agree with the information given in Reading Passage 2?

TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

14 The population of Dar es Salaam is rising more rapidly than was previously predicted.

15 Most of the residents of Dar es Salaam live in high-rise blocks on the edge of the city.

16 Residents have been consulted about their views on the suburban rail line in Dar es Salaam.

17 The majority of the present residential development in Dar es Salaam is unplanned.

18 Dar es Salaam's authorities have decided to follow the public transport plan adopted by a large number of African cities.

Questions 19-26

Complete the notes below.

Choose ONE WORD ONLY from the passage for each answer.

Dar es Salaam's DART Bus Rapid Transit system

Features

- the buses use designated **19** 19 to cut down on delays
- passengers pay fares before **20** 20
- passengers in **21** 21 can use every part of the system

Problems

- the temperature control is sometimes not activated in order to reduce **22** 22 use
- insufficient number of vehicles are available due to the effects of a severe **23** 23
- passengers are unable to use **24** 24 because some equipment is out of action
- tickets have to be checked manually at station **25** 25
- **26** 26 frequently build up during rush hours



You should spend about 20 minutes on Questions 27–40, which are based on Reading Passage 3 below.

Rethinking the Past

It is by now a truism that the story of human evolution is being rethought. Discoveries have come thick and fast over the last decade or so, and these have forced us to rethink many crucial points, such as how old our species is - about 300,000 years old as opposed to 200,000 - and what extinct hominins, such as our cousins the Neanderthals, were really like. But because there are so many species and eras involved, it's hard to discern the common threads linking them.

However, I do think it's possible to draw out some overall messages from the blizzard of archaeological finds in recent years. Two things stand out to me. One is the growing evidence that many supposedly 'advanced' behaviours, such as architecture and art, can be traced much further back in time than we thought, often to hominin species that existed before modern humans. And the other is that we have badly misunderstood gender roles in prehistoric societies, imposing patriarchal values onto cultures that had very different ideas about how women should behave.

Let's start with architecture. At Kalambo Falls in Zambia, researchers found buried logs that had been shaped with stone tools so that they interlocked. They seem to have once been part of a larger structure, perhaps a building. This would be unsurprising if they weren't 476,000 years old. That's almost 200,000 years before our species, *Homo sapiens*, evolved. Extinct hominins also managed to settle in extreme places. For instance, we now know that extinct hominins such as the Denisovans lived on the frozen heights of high-altitude regions 200,000 years ago - upending the old notion that such environments were only settled by modern humans around 3,600 years ago.

Art also seems to have been invented by older hominins. We have had evidence for a long time now that Neanderthals painted on cave walls. Even earlier species, such as *Homo erectus*, may also have made art, for example by engraving patterns on shells. By far the most contentious claim in this area is that *Homo naledi* made art. *H. naledi* lived around 250,000 years ago, making it a contemporary of our species. However, it had quite a small brain, typical of older hominins - and was therefore, according to palaeoanthropological dogma, incapable of complex behaviours. Nevertheless, in the Rising Star cave system in South Africa where the *H. naledi* remains were found, researchers have found what seem to be etchings - resembling rudimentary artwork - on the cave walls, though these have yet to be firmly dated.

To say these claims about *H. naledi* are controversial is to understate the situation. Many experts say the evidence presented so far is completely inadequate to support them. The dispute has only been heightened by the way the results were released, in a non-traditional journal that publishes peer reviews publicly alongside the paper. My views on the *H. naledi* controversy are complicated. I do think more evidence is needed: in particular with regard to the dating of the etchings. At the same time, I think the species' small brains are a distraction. Palaeoanthropologists got fixated on brain size because it was what they could see: if what you have is skeletons, then all you know about brains are their shapes and sizes. But other properties, such as the brain's internal wiring, are surely equally important and may explain how a species like *H. naledi* might have been capable of complex behaviours, despite their small brains.

In a sense, we shouldn't be surprised that so many of these behaviours had their origins in older, extinct hominins. Evolution usually works by incremental steps and so does technology. The first birds weren't great at flying, and the first mobile phones weren't great at, well, anything really. The idea that there was a sudden explosion of intelligence and creativity at some point in our evolution isn't inherently ridiculous: sometimes a system hits a tipping point and undergoes runaway change. But there was never that much evidence that human evolution worked this way. Instead, it seems the Neanderthals and many others all walked so we could run.

One way or another, the H. naledi story is going to be an example of letting our preconceptions get in the way of the evidence. The same is true for our ideas about gender in prehistory. Archaeology was invented by individuals with now unfashionably patriarchal views about gender, and those notions fed into their research. Today's researchers are trying to unpick this stuff, and there have been some significant steps in recent years.

Perhaps the most dramatic was the demolition of 'Man the Hunter'. This was the idea, promoted for decades, that in most prehistoric societies the men went out to hunt and the women looked after the home. However, a meta-analysis published in June 2023 compiled data on several dozen foraging societies and found women hunted in 80 per cent of them. In line with this, it emerged that an ancient spear-throwing tool called an atlatl enables women to launch projectiles at the same speed as men. We have also seen growing evidence of women occupying positions of authority in ancient societies. The Viking queen Thyra may have helped unify Denmark in the 900s. Going further back, an Iberian leader from around 4000 years ago turned out to be female, not male as many had assumed, when proteins in her teeth were analysed.

It seems that the more we find out about past societies, the more our preconceptions about the ways society 'has to be' turn out to be wrong. Inequality, authoritarianism and patriarchy aren't inevitable. They're choices, and prehistory shows us that we can choose differently.

PART 3 — QUESTIONS

Part 3

Questions 27-30

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

27 What is the writer doing in the second paragraph?

- A** pinpointing some key changes in our understanding of prehistory
- B** outlining some aspects of prehistory which are still poorly understood
- C** summarising some attitudes towards recent archaeological revelations
- D** giving an overview of some current disagreements among archaeologists

28 In the sixth paragraph, the writer mentions mobile phones to make the point that

- A** most developments happen in a gradual way.
- B** innovation can come from a variety of sources.
- C** not all technological advancements are positive.
- D** the path of evolution can often be unpredictable.

29 In the seventh paragraph, the phrase 'unpick this stuff' refers to the task of

- A** assessing the impact of certain recent research findings.
- B** questioning the authenticity of evidence used in earlier research.
- C** conducting research into how prehistoric societies were organised.
- D** reevaluating research influenced by outdated beliefs about society.

30 What does the writer suggest in the final paragraph?

- A** Studying past societies could help us create a fairer society today.
- B** We should not judge past societies by the standards of modern society.
- C** We still have much to learn about how societies have evolved over history.
- D** There is more than one way to interpret evidence about societies in prehistoric times.

Questions 31-34

- A. Homo sapiens emerged at an earlier point in time than experts previously believed.
- B. Previous assumptions about who had power in the prehistoric world were inaccurate.
- C. Gender roles in extinct hominin species were different from those in Homo sapiens societies.
- D. Experts may have been mistaken about who looked for food in early human communities.
- E. Homo sapiens was probably not the only species capable of sophisticated workmanship.
- F. Other species managed to survive in harsh environments before the arrival of Homo sapiens.

Complete each sentence with the correct ending, A-F, below.

- The findings at Kalambo Falls revealed that **31**
- Evidence from high-altitude regions suggests that **32**
- An academic publication from June 2023 shows that **33**
- Analysis of a 4000-year-old Iberian leader indicates that **34**

Questions 35-40

Do the following statements agree with the views of the writer in Reading Passage 3?

- YES** if the statement agrees with the views of the writer
NO if the statement contradicts the views of the writer
NOT GIVEN if it is impossible to say what the writer thinks about this

YES	if the statement agrees with the claims of the writer
NO	if the statement contradicts the claims of the writer
NOT GIVEN	if it is impossible to say what the writer thinks about this

35 It seems likely that the Neanderthals' cave paintings were the first examples of artwork ever created.

36 It is very rare to find prehistoric artwork carved onto shells.

37 The methods which the researchers used to examine the Rising Star cave system were rather unconventional.

38 It is unclear how old the etchings in the Rising Star cave system are.

39 The means used to publicise the findings from the Rising Star cave system added to the controversy that surrounds them.

40 The size of *H. naledi* brains is a key factor in the question of whether these hominins were able to produce art.

ANSWER KEY

Answer Key & Explanations

#	Correct Answer	Explanation
1	dust	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage explains that the saiga has a special nose that does many helpful things. It keeps dirt out of the animal, helps keep its blood cool when it is hot outside, and makes the air warm before the animal breathes it in during the winter. Answer Explanation: The answer is 'dust', which refers to tiny pieces of dirt or sand that float in the air. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is 'dust' because the passage explains that the saiga's special nose has nostrils that 'filter out' this material. In this context, to 'filter out' means to trap or keep something from getting inside while letting air pass through. This is an adaptation that helps the animal live in its dry environment.
2	blood	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage explains that the saiga's large nose helps the animal in three ways: it stops dust from entering, it makes its blood cooler in the summer, and it makes the air warmer before the animal breathes it in during the winter. Answer Explanation: The answer is the word 'blood', which refers to the red liquid that flows through the bodies of animals and humans. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is 'blood' because the passage states that one purpose of the saiga's swollen nostrils is to 'cool the blood during hot, dry summers'. In the notes, the phrase 'lower the temperature' is a synonym for 'cool', matching the information provided in the text.
3	coat	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage explains that besides its special nose, the saiga also grows thick fur for the cold winter, which falls off once the season changes and it gets warmer. Answer Explanation: The answer "coat" refers to the thick layer of fur or hair that grows on the animal's body to keep it warm. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is "coat" because the passage identifies a "heavy winter coat" as a seasonal adaptation. The notes mention that the saiga grows this thick layer in winter and "loses" it in spring; this matches the text which says the animal "sheds" (meaning to lose hair naturally) the coat when the weather "warms up" (which happens in spring).
4	horns	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage says that male saiga are hunted most often because their horns are worth a lot of money to people who make traditional medicine. Answer Explanation: The answer refers to the hard, pointed parts that grow from the heads of certain animals.

#	Correct Answer	Explanation
		Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is 'horns' because the text explains that hunters specifically went after male saiga to get these parts of their bodies. These body parts were very valuable for traditional medicine. This targeted hunting caused a huge drop in the number of saiga.
5	habitat	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage says that the saiga losing its home (habitat) is a big problem. This happens because people are creating more farms and building more places to live. Answer Explanation: The answer "habitat" means the natural environment or the home where an animal lives. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is "habitat" because the passage identifies "loss of habitat" as a specific consequence of "agricultural expansion and human settlement." The notes use the phrase "expansion of farms" as a synonym for "agricultural expansion" and "settlements" for "human settlement." In this context, "loss" corresponds to the "reduction in the size" mention in the notes, making "habitat" the correct word to describe what is shrinking.
6	routes	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage explains that things built by humans, such as train tracks or fences, can stop the animals from using the natural paths they travel on during different seasons. Answer Explanation: The answer "routes" refers to the specific paths or ways the saiga antelopes travel when they move from one area to another during different times of the year. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is "routes" because the passage identifies human-made structures like fences and railways as "physical barriers." These barriers prevent the animals from accessing their "migration routes," which are the natural paths they follow to find food or better weather. The text links the loss of access to these paths directly to the movement of the species.
7	streams	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage states that the land has become very dry and that many small rivers, which the saiga needed to survive, have disappeared. Answer Explanation: The answer "streams" refers to small rivers or bodies of flowing water that the saiga needed for water, but which have now gone away. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is "streams" because the text identifies climate change as a factor making the region more arid (dry). It mentions that "smaller streams" which the saiga "depended on" (relied on) have now "dried up and vanished," which matches the prompt's description of a disappearance caused by climate change.
8	False	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage explains that Kazakhstan has almost all of the saiga in the world (over 90%), while the other three countries together have only the small amount that is left. This shows the numbers are very different in each country, not the same. Answer Explanation: The answer means that the saiga population is not split in equal amounts across the four countries mentioned. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is FALSE because the passage states that Kazakhstan is home to more than 90% of the total saiga population. This means that the other three countries—Russia, Mongolia, and Uzbekistan—only share the tiny remaining portion (less than 10%). Because most of the animals are in just one country, they are not distributed 'evenly' (in equal amounts) as the question suggests.

#	Correct Answer	Explanation
9	False	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage explains that laws helped the saiga survive, and their population numbers actually grew larger during most of the 1900s. Answer Explanation: The answer is FALSE because the number of saiga antelopes did not go down during most of the 1900s. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is FALSE because the passage explicitly states that saiga numbers "steadily recovered" for the majority of the 20th century. To "recover" means to return to a normal or better state, which in this context means the population size was increasing rather than falling. While they faced a major decline after 1991, the statement in the question refers to "most of the 20th century," which contradicts the factual information provided in the text.
10	True	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage explains that people tried to protect African rhinos by telling others to use saiga horns for traditional medicine. Because of this, hunters killed so many male saigas that the number of these animals went down very fast, and they have had a hard time surviving ever since. Answer Explanation: The answer means it is true that trying to save rhinos in Africa caused a major change for the saiga antelope. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is TRUE because the text explains how efforts to help rhinos actually caused problems for saigas. People who wanted to protect rhinos suggested using saiga horns for medicine instead. This caused a massive increase in illegal hunting, or 'poaching,' which led to a 'population crash' where the number of saigas dropped very quickly because so many males were killed.
11	Not Given	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage mentions that changing weather and unexpected shifts in temperature are a problem for the saiga, but it does not provide any information about other regions to allow for a comparison. Answer Explanation: The answer is NOT GIVEN because the text does not say whether climate changes in Central Asia are more dangerous than those in other parts of the world. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is NOT GIVEN because while the passage discusses how "unpredictable fluctuations in climate" are a danger to the saiga antelope in Central Asia, it never mentions or compares this threat to the situation in any other part of the world. For a statement to be TRUE or FALSE, the text must provide specific details for a comparison, but here that information is missing.
12	True	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage says that the goal of this project is to fix and protect local nature areas and all the different kinds of animals (many species) that live in those places, which includes the saiga. Answer Explanation: The answer states that the Altyn Dala Conservation Initiative was created to help more than just one kind of animal. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is TRUE because the passage explains that while the initiative focuses on the saiga, its broader goal is to protect the whole environment and the 'many species' that live there. The word 'species' refers to different types of animals or plants, and 'many' means a large number. This confirms the initiative was formed to benefit a range of different animals, not just the saiga.
13	Not Given	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage says the United Nations gave the project a special prize for being one of the ten best examples of fixing nature in the world, but there is no information about money. Answer Explanation: The answer is not given because the passage mentions that the project received an award, but it does not say if this award helped the project get more

#	Correct Answer	Explanation
		money. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is NOT GIVEN because while the text explains that the United Nations gave the Altyn Dala Conservation Initiative a special title or award (a 'World Restoration Flagship project'), it never mentions whether this led to 'additional international funding' (more money from other countries). In IELTS Reading, if the specific detail requested—in this case, the increase in money—is not mentioned in the text, the answer must be NOT GIVEN.
14	Not Given	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage lists guesses for the future population size made by the United Nations and a specific expert. However, these are current predictions, and the text does not say how they compare to older predictions from earlier years. Answer Explanation: The answer means that the passage does not tell us if the growth of the city is faster or slower than what people expected in the past. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is NOT GIVEN because while the text provides facts about the current growth and future guesses about the population, it never mentions any older predictions from the past. To confirm the statement as true or false, the text would need to compare the current speed of growth to what was 'previously predicted.' Since there is no information about past expectations, we cannot determine if the population is rising more rapidly than them.
15	False	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage states that 80% (four out of every five) of the population lives in one-floor houses located on the outer parts of the city. Answer Explanation: The answer is FALSE because the statement says people live in tall buildings (high-rise blocks), but the text says they live in buildings with only one level (single-storey). Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is FALSE because the passage states that 'four out of five' people in the city—which means a majority or 'most'—live in 'single-storey' settlements. 'Single-storey' refers to a building with only one floor, which is the exact opposite of 'high-rise blocks' mentioned in the question. While the location mentioned in the statement ('edge of the city') matches the text's 'spreading edges', the description of the buildings makes the whole statement factually incorrect based on the passage.
16	Not Given	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage says that there is one train line for people living in the south, but it does not say if the city asked the people for their thoughts or feedback about it. Answer Explanation: The answer is NOT GIVEN because the passage does not provide information about whether people living in the city were asked for their opinions on the train system. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is NOT GIVEN because while the text mentions the existence of a 'suburban rail line', it never says whether the residents were 'consulted' or asked for their 'views' about it. The passage only describes the rail line's location and notes that it is very small compared to the size of the whole city.
17	True	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage tells us that almost all new buildings are being put up at the edges of the city without any official or organized plan. Answer Explanation: The answer TRUE means that most of the new homes being built in Dar es Salaam are not part of an official government plan. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is TRUE because the passage says that almost all new growth in the city happens 'informally' and 'without any agreed strategy.'

#	Correct Answer	Explanation
		These terms mean the growth is unplanned. Additionally, the phrase 'Nearly all' in the text confirms that this is true for the 'majority' of the development mentioned in the question.
18	False	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage explains that Dar es Salaam is not like many other cities in Africa. Other cities are focused on building trains, but Dar es Salaam picked buses because they are less expensive and easier to create. Answer Explanation: The answer is FALSE because Dar es Salaam's leaders did not follow the same public transport plan as many other African cities; they chose a different one. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is FALSE because the passage states that Dar es Salaam is doing something different from many other cities on the continent. While many other cities are trying to build 'metros' (underground or light rail trains), Dar es Salaam has decided to use a 'bus' system instead. The word 'Unlike' is a key synonym for 'different from', showing that Dar es Salaam's choice is not the same as the typical plan used by a large number of other African cities.
19	lanes	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage states that the DART buses travel on specific parts of the road called lanes. Because these lanes are separated from other types of traffic, the buses do not have to stop as much as cars do. Answer Explanation: The answer "lanes" refers to special paths on the road made specifically for buses to drive in so they can avoid traffic from other cars. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is "lanes" because the text explains that the DART bus system uses its own paths that are kept apart from other vehicles. These are called "bus lanes." By driving in these special areas, the buses don't have to stop as often for traffic, which helps reduce delays or "stoppages."
20	boarding	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage states that the process of buying and checking tickets happens at the bus stations before a passenger actually gets on the bus. Answer Explanation: The answer "boarding" means the act of getting onto a bus, train, or plane. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is "boarding" because the passage explains that the system is designed for people to buy and check their tickets at the bus stations before they get on the vehicle. The phrase "prior to boarding" in the text directly matches the meaning of paying "before" getting on the bus as mentioned in the notes.
21	wheelchairs	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage explains that since there are no stairs to climb when getting on the bus, people moving in wheelchairs can travel along the whole bus route. Answer Explanation: The answer "wheelchairs" refers to the special chairs with wheels that help people who cannot walk to move from one place to another. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is "wheelchairs" because the passage discusses how the DART system is designed to be easy for everyone to use. It mentions that because the buses do not have steps, the whole path is "accessible" (meaning easy to reach or use) for people who are using "wheelchairs".
22	fuel	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage says that some bus drivers choose not to use the cooling system in the vehicles so that they do not use up too much gas or energy. Answer Explanation: The answer "fuel" refers to the energy source (like gasoline or diesel) that the bus needs to move and run its internal systems, such as air conditioning.

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		Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is derived from a complaint made by a passenger in the passage. The notes mention that "temperature control" (which refers to air conditioning) is sometimes not used to reduce the use of a specific resource. The text explicitly states that drivers do not turn on the air conditioning because they want to "save fuel." Therefore, "fuel" is the resource being saved or used less.
23	flood	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage says that the bus system is only carrying half the people it should because many buses are missing after a major water event (a flood) hit the bus station. Answer Explanation: The answer 'flood' refers to a large amount of water covering an area that is usually dry, often caused by heavy rain. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is 'flood' because the text explains that there are not enough buses (a 'shortage') because of a 'serious flood' that happened at the place where the buses are kept (the depot). In the question, the phrase 'insufficient number of vehicles' means there are not enough buses, and 'severe' is a synonym for 'serious'.
24	smartcards	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage says that people cannot use their electronic travel cards because the machines that read them are broken. Because these machines don't work, people have to buy paper tickets instead. Answer Explanation: The answer refers to digital payment cards that people use to pay for their travel. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is "smartcards" because the passage mentions that they cannot be used at the moment. This is because the "mechanical readers" (the machines or equipment used to scan the cards) are not working or are "out of action."
25	gates	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage explains that due to broken scanners, workers are positioned at the station entrances to physically tear the paper tickets as commuters go inside. Answer Explanation: The answer "gates" refers to the entry points at the bus stations where staff members must manually check or tear passenger tickets. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is supported by the passage's description of technical failures within the ticketing system. Because the QR code scanners are non-functional, employees are forced to perform the task of ticket verification by hand. The text specifies that these employees perform this manual task while standing at the gates, which aligns with the notes stating that tickets are checked manually at station gates.
26	queues	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage explains that long lines of people (queues) form during the busiest times of the day (peak times) because the ticketing system is not working perfectly. Answer Explanation: The answer 'queues' refers to lines of people waiting for their turn to be served or to move forward. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is 'queues' because the passage explicitly mentions that because of the manual ticket-checking process, lines of people become quite long during the busiest parts of the day. In the passage, 'considerable' suggests they 'build up' or become large, and 'peak times' is a common synonym for 'rush hours'.
27	A	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage highlights two major points where our old ideas have been updated. It mentions that "advanced" activities like art were done by

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		species older than humans, and it explains that we have "badly misunderstood" how women lived in the past. Answer Explanation: The answer A means the writer is identifying specific and important ways that our knowledge about people in the very distant past has changed because of new information. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is A because the writer uses this paragraph to point out two main "messages" or shifts in our knowledge. First, the writer explains that new evidence shows that building and art are much older than scientists used to believe. Second, the writer mentions that researchers are realizing they were wrong about how women and men behaved in those times. These two points represent "key changes" in our understanding of prehistory.
28	A	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage explains that both nature and the tools we build change using small, slow steps. It uses the example of early mobile phones—which did not work very well at first—to show that technology develops gradually over time. Answer Explanation: The answer means that most new things or changes happen slowly, step by step, rather than all at once. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is A because the writer uses the example of mobile phones to show that technology, much like evolution, moves in 'incremental steps.' This means that things change and improve little by little over time. By saying that the first mobile phones 'weren't great,' the writer is making a point about how progress is usually a slow, gradual process instead of a sudden, perfect explosion of new ideas.
29	D	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage explains that the first archaeologists had biased ideas about men and women, which changed how they did their research. Today, scientists are trying to take apart and look closely at those old research ideas ('unpick this stuff') to see if they were wrong. Answer Explanation: The answer means looking again at old scientific studies that were influenced by old-fashioned and unfair ideas about how men and women should act in society. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is D because the author explains that the field of archaeology was created by people with 'patriarchal views'—old-fashioned beliefs that men were more important or took on all the main roles. These 'notions' or beliefs affected how they interpreted their findings. To 'unpick this stuff' refers to the work current researchers are doing to re-examine that old research and remove the influence of those biased beliefs.
30	A	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage explains that unfair ways of running a society are not unavoidable; instead, they are decisions people make. It suggests that by looking at how our ancestors lived, we can see that we have the power to make better choices for our own society. Answer Explanation: The answer means that learning about how people lived a long time ago can show us that we are able to build a better and more equal world today. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is A because the final paragraph says that things like unfairness (inequality) and one person or group having too much power (authoritarianism and patriarchy) are not things that "have to be." Use of the word "inevitable" means something is certain to happen, but the author argues these are actually "choices." Therefore, looking at "prehistory" (the time before written records) proves that humans can live in a different way, suggesting we can choose to create a fairer society now.

#	Correct Answer	Explanation
31	E. Homo sapiens was probably not the only species capable of sophisticated workmanship.	No explanation available.
32	F. Other species managed to survive in harsh environments before the arrival of Homo sapiens.	No explanation available.
33	D. Experts may have been mistaken about who looked for food in early human communities.	No explanation available.
34	B. Previous assumptions about who had power in the prehistoric world were inaccurate.	No explanation available.
35	No	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage says that different types of early humans who lived before the Neanderthals might have also made art, such as by carving designs onto shells. Answer Explanation: The answer NO means the writer does not agree that Neanderthals were the first ones to create art. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is NO because the writer says that species even older than Neanderthals, like Homo erectus, might have made art first. Since Homo erectus lived before Neanderthals and may have made art by marking shells, it is not likely that Neanderthals made the very first art.
36	Not Given	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage says that very old human relatives might have carved designs into shells to make art, but it does not mention if we find these shells often or only once in a while. Answer Explanation: The answer is NOT GIVEN because the passage does not say how easy or hard it is to find artwork carved into shells from long ago. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is NOT GIVEN because the text only mentions that an early species called *Homo erectus* might have made art by "engraving patterns on shells." It uses this as an example of art-making behavior, but the author never provides information about the frequency or rarity of these discoveries. Without words like "rare," "uncommon," or "frequent," we cannot know if the writer thinks finding these shells is a rare event.
37	Not Given	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage states that the scientists used an unusual way to share their news with others, but it says nothing about the ways they actually worked inside the cave to find their evidence. Answer Explanation: The answer means that the text does not provide enough information to know if the writer believes the way the researchers studied the cave was

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		unusual or normal. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is NOT GIVEN because while the text mentions that the 'way the results were released' was 'non-traditional' (unconventional), it does not mention the 'methods' (the specific tools or steps) that were used to 'examine' (search or study) the Rising Star cave system. Because the passage only discusses how the news was shared with the public, and not the actual scientific work done inside the cave, we cannot determine the writer's view on this point.
38	Yes	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage mentions that while researchers found markings on the walls of the Rising Star cave, they have not yet given them a specific or certain age. Answer Explanation: The answer YES means the writer agrees that we do not know the exact age of the markings (etchings) found in the Rising Star cave yet. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is YES because the text states that the markings in the cave 'have yet to be firmly dated.' In English, if something has not been 'firmly dated,' it means scientists have not yet found enough proof to say exactly when it was created. Because there is no certain date, the age of these objects is currently 'unclear,' which matches the statement in the question.
39	Yes	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage explains that the argument about the discovery became worse because of the specific way the scientists chose to publish their news in a magazine that does not follow the usual rules. Answer Explanation: The answer means that the method used to share the discovery at the Rising Star cave system with the public made the disagreement among scientists even bigger. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is YES because the author explicitly states that the 'dispute' (meaning the controversy or argument) was 'heightened' (meaning it became stronger or was added to) by how the results were shared ('the way the results were released'). The passage identifies that the specific 'means used' was a 'non-traditional journal,' and this choice of publication increased the tension surrounding the findings.
40	No	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage shows that the writer believes it is a mistake to focus too much on how big or small the H. naledi brains were when trying to understand their skills. Answer Explanation: The answer NO means the writer's opinion is different from the statement; the writer doesn't believe brain size is a main reason for deciding if H. naledi could make art. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is NO because the author describes the focus on the small brains of H. naledi as a 'distraction.' A distraction is something that takes your attention away from what is actually important. The writer thinks that simply looking at the size of the brain is not a 'key factor' or a helpful way to judge if a species was smart enough to make art. Instead, the author suggests that the 'internal wiring' (how the brain works inside) is more important than the size.